

1 When / Where

January 7 to April 6, 2026

Online: Wednesdays and Fridays 11:30 AM - 12:50 PM, through **Teams**

Office hours by appointment



4

How You'll Be Assessed



- **TCPS-2 Course:** 5%, Jan 18
- **In-Class Engagement and Collaboration:** 22%, throughout
- **Pop Quizzes:** 33%, random
- **Mini Literature Review:** 10%, Feb 8
- **Focus Group:** 15%, Feb 27 (discussion guide and facilitation) and Mar 8 (thematic analysis)
- **Survey:** 15%, Mar 22 (instrument development) and Mar 29 (critical review)

5 Important Policies

- Students required to turn cameras on during class.
- Late assignments deducted 5% per day.
- Quizzes and some assignments not eligible for extensions.
- APA 7th Edition in-text citation style.

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What You'll Learn



You will move through the entire **health research cycle**—from reading media reports to conducting a lit review, running your own focus group, analyzing qualitative data, then building and critiquing a survey instrument.

By the end, you will have performed each major stage of **mixed-methods** research. And you'll be better equipped to **critically appraise health information**.



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Weekly Themes

- Four pillars of health research
- Health research literacy
- Conducting a literature review
- Research paradigms
- Qualitative study designs
- Quantitative study designs
- Participatory action research
- Program evaluation
- Ethical considerations
- Two-Eyed Seeing
- Research to action



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3

In-Class Expectations

Complete readings **BEFORE** Wednesday's lecture.

Each class will include a lecture, some interactive workshop activities, including **graded in-class engagement activities based on the reading**.

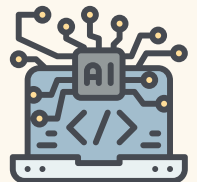
Pop quizzes will also happen during class time. If you miss class, there will not be make up opportunities.

Cameras on policy in effect!



7

Policy on Generative AI



Feel free to use GAI-driven tools to assist your learning – for grammar, sentence structure and generating ideas, but you are **prohibited from using GAI to produce work you submit**, including Quizzes, Media Analysis, Mini Literature Review, Focus Group or Survey Assignments.

AI tools can be used to help you learn - brainstorming ideas, checking grammar, or clarifying concepts - but must not replace your thinking or appear in any submitted assignment.



Syllabus

HLTH 1011

Winter 2026

Foundations of Health Inquiry

**Online: Wednesdays and Fridays 11:30 AM - 12:50 PM, through Teams
January 7 to April 6, 2026**

**Instructor:
San Patten, MSc.
Email: spatten@mta.ca**

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Territorial Acknowledgment

I would like to first acknowledge that we are located within the territory of Mi'kma'ki, the unceded, ancestral territory of the Mi'kmaq. Our relationship and our privilege to live on this territory was agreed upon in the Peace and Friendship Treaties of 1752. Acknowledging this traditional territory, and its experience of colonialism, reminds us to consider our relationship with the land, its natural gifts and our fellow creatures. This land knows too well the ongoing impacts of colonialism, which has a violent history spanning more than 400 years before our time, and my presence here as a second-generation settler means I have social responsibility to reconcile for those past wrongs and those still happening. And this responsibility extends to our human relations as well as the rest of the natural world in which we reside.

The purpose of a land acknowledgment is to remind ourselves that this land isn't ours, that our government committed crimes against humanity to build this country, that the violence of colonialism exists today in both overt and covert ways, and that we have a role to play in reconciliation right now and every day.

Your Instructor

San Patten, MSc.

Department of Sociology

Email: spatten@mta.ca (preferred method of contact)

Office Hours: by appointment only

Please feel free to ask me for a meeting time. I'm always happy to chat with students, either to provide extra assistance or advice, to discuss course content in more depth, or just to talk about the state of our world and your life plans.

If you email me, you can expect to receive a response within 12 hours on weekdays or by Monday morning if you email over the weekend. In case of the need to communicate emergency information, class cancellations or other unforeseen circumstances, I will send an announcement through Moodle.

My Teaching Philosophy: I have a teaching style that is very participatory and experiential, and I focus on helping students find real-world application of theory through community development, organizational development, research and evaluation, policy analysis and advocacy projects. I see myself more as a facilitator than an expert, and that means students are required to engage in active learning, taking a lead in their own education with me as a guide.

Course Description

Health research can influence political policies, improve the health of the community, advance patient care and identify emerging and existing health problems. Whether your interest is in health promotion, nursing, medicine, kinesiology or recreation studies this course will provide you with the necessary building blocks to help you understand the research process. This course will introduce fundamentals of health-related research methods with a focus on developing critical reasoning skills. Using examples from a wide range of health-related research topics, students will gain familiarity and skills to assess primary literature at a basic level.

This course provides an introduction to the fundamentals of study design, methods and data collection. It serves as an introduction to quantitative, qualitative, mixed method and participatory approaches to research, as well as ethical issues in conducting research. A key emphasis in this course is developing information literacy, examining the origins of the information, evaluating the trustworthiness of the sources and the media outlet, and identifying any misrepresentations. You will gain practice at critically evaluating media information in a way that is consistent with the practices of modern research science. You will be able to critically assess how health research is communicated and the context in which research is performed.

You will move through the entire health research cycle—from reading media reports to conducting a lit review, running your own focus group, analyzing qualitative data, then building and critiquing a survey instrument. By the end, you will have performed each major stage of mixed-methods research.

Objectives

In this course, I aim to provide you with a conceptual framework and the tools to empower you to critically evaluate information presented at a variety of levels and to encourage you to develop your own informed opinions. Critical literacy is a crucial set of skills that will provide benefit to you as a student and an individual, regardless of your program of study. Specifically, by successfully completing this course, you will be able to:

- Understand the fundamentals of qualitative and quantitative health research
- Understand the scientific context behind media reports of health-related discoveries
- Develop skills in finding and assessing information and recognizing its limitations
- Gain insight into how health sciences research is communicated
- Develop transferable skills in reading scientific papers, researching and accessing a variety of literature sources, critically evaluating the quality of the things that you are reading, and communicating findings.
- Identify the range of appropriate quantitative and qualitative research methods to understand or measure a health issue
- Develop familiarity with the range of health research approaches: biomedical research, clinical research, health services & policy research, and social, cultural, environmental & population health research
- Gain comfort in reading and understanding research literature about clinical trials, observational studies in epidemiology, qualitative studies and program evaluation
- Understand ethics principles when collecting, maintaining, using, and disseminating data from human subjects.

Pre-requisites

This is a first-year course as part of the Bachelor of Arts and Science (BASc) in Interdisciplinary Health Studies. Pre-requisite for this course is HLTH 1001 (Health and Society).

Course Delivery Format

This course is offered in online format through Teams. All course materials (syllabus, readings, lecture materials, assignment details) will be delivered through the on-line Moodle tool [<http://moodle.mta.ca>] **You will be assigned a reading each week to prepare for class – please be sure to read it BEFORE Wednesday’s lecture. Each class will include a lecture, some interactive workshop activities, including graded in-class engagement requirements.**



If you are having problems with Moodle, contact the Help Desk immediately at helpdesk@mta.ca.

Online: Wednesdays and Fridays 11:30AM - 12:50PM, through Teams. [Here is the link.](#)

Learning Resources

REQUIRED READINGS

There is no textbook for this course. Instead, readings or other learning resources will be posted on Moodle.

Each weekly module will be linked to a set of required readings from journals, reports or books. It is essential that you come to Tuesday’s class having completed the readings, ready to discuss them.

INTERNET RESOURCES

If applicable, web links for each unit’s reading(s) will be included under each week’s “Topic.” You may also need to access additional literature from websites and electronic journals and the Mount Allison University Library system, in order to complete assignments.

We will use the Resources box within Moodle to post references and web links for any supplemental resources that may be of interest to the class.

Student Evaluation

Students are expected to complete readings, review lecture material, contribute to class discussions and play your part in creating an engaging online learning environment. There are no midterm or final exams in this course. Instead, learning will be assessed through a variety of individual and group assignments, as detailed below:

Assignment	Value	Due Date
Completion of TCPS 2 Course on Research Ethics Modules 1-9. Create an account and complete modules at this website: https://tcps2core.ca/welcome	5%	Jan 18
In-Class Engagement and Collaboration	22%	random
Pop Quizzes	33%	random
Mini Literature Review	10%	Feb 8
1) Focus Group Guide and Facilitation 2) Focus Group Data Analysis and Peer Review	15%	1) Feb 27 2) Mar 8
1) Survey Instrument Development 2) Survey Critical Review and Peer Review	15%	1) Mar 22 2) Mar 29

TCPS 2 Course on Research Ethics

5%
Due Jan 18

It is important that you understand the fundamentals of ethics regarding research involving human participants. The Tri-Council Policy Statement: Ethical Conduct for Research Involving Humans (TCPS 2) provides ethics guidance that applies to all research involving human participants – including their data and/or biological materials – conducted under the auspices of an institution eligible for funding by Canada's federal Agencies (CIHR, NSERC, SSHRC).

The online tutorial CORE-2022 (Course on Research Ethics) is applicable to all research involving human participants, regardless of discipline or methodology.

CORE-2022 consists of nine modules and a knowledge consolidation exercise:

- Module A1 – Introduction
- Module A2 – Scope of TCPS 2
- Module A3 – Risks and Benefits
- Module A4 – Consent
- Module A5 – Fairness and Equity
- Module A6 – Privacy and Confidentiality
- Module A7 – Conflicts of Interest
- Module A8 – Research Ethics Board Review
- Module A9 – Research Involving Indigenous Peoples
- Knowledge Consolidation Exercise

The modules are numbered in the suggested order. However, they can be completed in any order and can be used to review individual topics. Each module ends with 4-5 quiz questions for you to test the knowledge that you have acquired. CORE-2022 also includes a knowledge consolidation exercise consisting of 25 multiple-choice questions randomly selected from a larger question bank. To obtain a **CORE-2022 Certificate of Completion**, you will need to correctly respond to 20 questions (80%). Those who do not correctly respond to at least 20 questions will not obtain a Certificate of Completion. However, they will have the opportunity to retake the knowledge consolidation exercise.

Completing CORE-2022 should take approximately 4 hours. The course is self-paced. It is therefore possible to complete the different modules over multiple sessions. All the modules must be completed before taking the knowledge consolidation exercise. To get the 5%, upload your Certificate of Completion to Moodle.

In-Class Engagement and Collaboration

22%

Creating a vibrant and collaborative learning environment is an important value for your instructor. Therefore, you are expected to attend each online class and participate in learning activities. Throughout the semester, classes will involve interactive activities or workshops, some of which require preparatory tasks in advance. Your active participation in the activities will be tallied over the semester and you will earn points only if: 1) you are present in class with your camera on; and 2) you actively contribute to the in-class activities. Each class will be recorded, and the instructor will select a random time within the recording to take a tally of cameras on. As per Camera On Policy (see page 6 below), if your camera is off, it will be considered an absence.

Pop Quizzes

12% for question submissions
21% for quizzes

Random throughout semester

Randomly throughout the semester, you will complete three pop quizzes that relate to the materials covered in readings and lectures up to the date of the quiz. The pop quiz will be administered through Moodle during class time. There will be a quiz on the last day of class (April 8th) but otherwise, the dates of the pop quizzes will not be announced in advance (that's what makes them 'pop'!) and no make-up times will be provided. Therefore, it's very important that you attend class.

The pop quizzes will be created collectively, with students submitting quiz questions through a Wiki on Moodle. Sam will select the best questions for the next pop quiz. Each week you will submit two quiz questions, for a credit of 1% per week (12% total). There will be three pop quizzes, each worth 7%.

Mini Literature Review

10%
Due Feb 8

Students will be divided into groups of 4 or 5, according to a shared interest in a health topic. Individually, you will conduct a literature review of peer-reviewed scientific articles related to that topic, drawing from at least one source from each type of health research: 1) biomedical research; 2) clinical research; 3) health services and policy research; and 4) social, cultural, environmental and population health research. Your literature review will summarize the evidence across these four types of health research and describe a wholistic picture of what is known about the chosen health topic. A detailed rubric is provided in Moodle.

Focus Group Moderators Guide

- 1) Group 5% Due Feb 27
- 2) Individual 10% Due Mar 8

- 1) In your groups of 4 or 5, according to a shared interest in a health topic, you will collaborate to draft a focus group guide for a 40-minute focus group investigating your topic. Your group will then facilitate a focus group with another group of students (on February 27th during class time) through breakout rooms in Teams.
- 2) Each student will review the recording and transcript for their focus group, and identify key themes that emerged from the focus group discussion. The key themes, with a description of each theme and sample quotes, will be submitted on Moodle. A detailed rubric is provided in Moodle.

Note: each student will complete a peer assessment of their groupmates' contributions to the project. Based on these peer assessments, your individual assignment (focus group thematic analysis) may be adjusted up or down.

Survey Instrument Development

- 1) Group 5% Due Mar 22
- 2) Individual 10% Due Mar 29

- 1) Based on the focus group themes, each group will collaborate in drafting an online survey instrument on a health topic. After survey responses from classmates are gathered, each student group will collaborate to compile results from the pre-test, and use feedback from their pretest to revise the survey instrument. The issues explored in the survey should build on the focus group themes, but can also go beyond topics covered in the focus group, as the group determines. The final revised survey will be graded (worth 5%).

- 2) Students will each be responsible for responding to the surveys of three other groups and providing a critical review of the survey design. The feedback on the survey design will be submitted as a Word document in Moodle, indicating the name of each of the three surveys they completed. Each student will be graded on the quality of their feedback (worth 10%). A detailed rubric is provided in Moodle.

Note: each student will complete a peer assessment of their groupmates' contributions to the project. Based on these peer assessments, your individual assignment (critical review of other surveys) may be adjusted up or down.

Policies on Assignments

Late assignments will be deducted 5% for every day past the deadline, including weekend days. Assignments handed in two weeks after the deadline will be given a grade of zero. Some assignments are time-sensitive (i.e., are presented on a specific day within class time) and thus are not amenable to extensions. Quizzes can not be written outside the original times.

All papers are to follow the APA 7th Edition **in-text citation style**. This is detailed in the [library website](#).

Drop Date

Feb 27, 2026 - End of withdrawal period for 3-credit winter term courses; any student who does not withdraw from these courses by this date will remain registered and will receive a final grade.

Academic Integrity

The Interdisciplinary Health Studies program's practice is that any work involving plagiarism will be given a grade of zero as a minimum penalty and may be more severe depending on the nature and extent of the breach of the norms of academic integrity. All work must be your own, written in your own words and NOT generated by artificial intelligence (e.g., ChatGPT). Students are expected to be familiar with Mt. Allison University's expectations regarding plagiarism, as outlined in the [Academic Integrity Policy](#).

Generative Artificial Intelligence (GAI) Restrictions

Feel free to use GAI-driven tools to assist your learning – for grammar, sentence structure and generating ideas, but you are prohibited from using GAI to produce work you submit, including Quizzes, Media Analysis, Mini Literature Review, Focus Group or Survey Assignments. Due to the nature of this course, it would be meaningless to assess students' learning if GAI tools were allowed to produce work. For this reason, and even if these tools will be valuable tool in your career, their use is restricted so that your learning may be accurately and appropriately assessed. Using AI-driven tools to support the production of submitted work constitutes an academic offence. Submitting GAI work as your own constitutes an academic integrity offence. If the work that you produce is suspected to misrepresent your own competencies, you may be asked to complete a supplemental assessment to evaluate your mastery of course outcomes, and you may be subject to a disciplinary hearing. AI tools can be used to help you learn – brainstorming ideas, checking grammar, or clarifying concepts – but must not replace your thinking or appear in any submitted assignment.

Netiquette and Cameras On Policy

Instructors use non-verbal cues from students to help them determine the extent to which the concepts they are aiming to communicate are being received and understood by students. When instructors have access to this type of feedback, they can adapt their teaching approach. In addition, being able to see one another facilitates a collaborative learning environment and makes the experience more enjoyable and engaging for everyone. Other advantages include increased engagement, reduced distraction, increased trust and better understanding. Most importantly, being able to see each other helps us to create a sense of community and human connection.

If your instructor uses interactive instructional methods during the class (e.g., breakout rooms, quizzes, polling) the expectation is that students participate in the learning activities to enhance their learning. The expectation is that HLTH 1011 students engage and conduct themselves in classes delivered via Teams like they would in face-to-face classes. To meet this expectation, it will **require that students turn on their cameras during class interactions**, in accordance with the guidelines outlined below.

Netiquette Guidelines:

- Unless otherwise specified by the instructor, the expectation is that cameras are on during the class.
- If during a class, you are unable to keep your camera on due to technical issues or a personal situation, inform the instructor before the start of class. If this is not possible, inform the instructor privately during the class via chat. You may also choose to inform everyone in the class. In these circumstances the expectation is that students still participate actively during the class via chat, voice, icons, etc. .
- If you need to attend to an urgent matter during the class, you can turn off your camera for a short period of time. For extended periods you are required to inform the instructor using the chat function.
- If your camera is off, it will be considered an absence.
- We strongly encourage you to join the Teams meeting 5 minutes before the start time of class to trouble shoot any technical difficulties you may encounter.

- Ensure that you join using your MTA account (through Teams or Outlook) so that your display name accurately shows “First Name Last Name” as it appears on your student ID. You may indicate a preferred name if you would like.
- If possible, find a quiet spot free of interruptions and background noise.
- You may wish to change your background image or blur your background image for privacy. When you are entering the Teams meeting, select “Background Filters” and choose your background as “standard blur” or select one of the background images.
- Keep your microphone off when not speaking to prevent background noise.
- To engage with your instructor and classmates, you can use the raise hand icon  or click on the chat icon to type something 

Grade Conversion

Below 50	F
50.0- 53.3	D-
53.4-56.6	D
56.7-59.9	D+
60.0-63.3	C-
63.4-66.6	C
66.7-69.9	C+
70.0-73.3	B-
73.4-76.6	B
76.7-79.9	B+
80.0-84.9	A-
85.0-89.9	A
90 and above	A+

Course Schedule

Week #	Lesson	This Week's Reading(s)	Activities and Assignments Due This Week
Week 1 Jan 5-11	Introductions and review of syllabus Four pillars of health research Review of key health concepts	Syllabus Complete TCPS CORE course	Review syllabus; familiarize yourself with Moodle course site Submit quiz questions for this week's content
Week 2 Jan 12-18	Health Research Literacy Hierarchies of evidence Media representations of health research	Savoia, E., Harriman, N. W., Piltch-Loeb, R., Bonetti, M., Toffolutti, V., & Testa, M. A. (2022). Exploring the Association between Misinformation Endorsement, Opinions on the Government Response, Risk Perception, and COVID-19 Vaccine Hesitancy in the US, Canada, and Italy. <i>Vaccines</i>, 10(5), 671.	Submit quiz questions for this week's content by Jan 18 Jan 18: deadline to submit certificate of completion of TCPS 2 Course on Research Ethics Modules 1-9.
Week 3 Jan 19-25	Conducting a Literature Review Library skills <u>Guest:</u> Stephen Geier, MTA STEM librarian	Chapter 3: Reviewing the Literature Chapter 15: Synthesis Research (both from Introduction to Health Research Methods: A Practical Guide)	Submit quiz questions for this week's content by Jan 25 Start working on Mini Literature Review
Week 4 Jan 26 – Feb 1	Research Paradigms Epistemology, Ontology and Methodology	Chapter 2: Research Paradigms (from Health Research Methods: A Canadian Perspective) Chapter 7: Overview of Study Designs (from Introduction to Health Research Methods: A Practical Guide)	Submit quiz questions for this week's content by Feb 1 Continue working on Mini Literature Review
Week 5 Feb 2-8	Qualitative Study Designs Interview and Focus Group methods	Chapter 9: Qualitative Health Research (from Health Research Methods: A Canadian Perspective) Chapter 13: Qualitative Studies (from Introduction to Health Research Methods: A Practical Guide)	Submit quiz questions for this week's content by Feb 8 Feb 8: Mini Literature Review Assignment due
Week 6 Feb 9-15	Quantitative Study Designs Cross-Sectional, Cohort, Case-Control, Randomized Control Trials, Ecological Studies	Chapter 6: Overview of Study Designs in Health (page 101-111) (from Health Research Methods: A Canadian Perspective) Chapter 7: Overview of Study Designs (from Introduction to Health Research Methods: A Practical Guide)	Submit quiz questions for this week's content by Feb 15 Work in small groups on focus group assignment
STUDY BREAK: Feb 16-20 no classes			
Week 7 Feb 23 – Mar 1	Quantitative Study Designs continued Survey design	Chapter 21: Questionnaire Development (from Introduction to Health Research Methods: A Practical Guide)	Feb 27: Focus Group Facilitation assignment due (in class) Submit quiz questions for this week's content by Mar 1 Work in small groups on survey development assignment

Week #	Lesson	This Week's Reading(s)	Activities and Assignments Due This Week
Week 8 Mar 2-8	Participatory Action Research Community-based research approaches <u>Guest:</u> Katharine Dunbar, McCain Postdoctoral Fellow, Health Studies Program	Ninomiya, M., George, N., George, J. et al. (2020). A community-driven and evidence-based approach to developing mental wellness strategies in First Nations: a program protocol. Research Involvement and Engagement: 6, 5.	Submit quiz questions for this week's content by Mar 8 Mar 8: Focus Group Analysis assignment due
Week 9 Mar 9-15	Program Evaluation Intervention science	Bowen, S. (2012). A Guide to Evaluation in Health Research. CIHR (pages 4-10). Community Toolbox: Measuring Success: Evaluating Comprehensive Community Initiatives	Submit quiz questions for this week's content by Mar 15
Week 10 Mar 16-22	Ethical Considerations Vulnerability, consent <u>Guest:</u> Greg Sandala, Director of Research Partnerships	Chapter 17: Ethical Considerations (from Introduction to Health Research Methods: A Practical Guide) Chapter 5: Applied Ethics (from Health Research Methods: A Canadian Perspective)	Submit quiz questions for this week's content by Mar 22 Mar 22: Survey development assignment due
Week 11 Mar 23-29	Two-Eyed Seeing Indigenous approaches to health research <u>Guest:</u> Sherry Pooyak, Indigenous Researcher	Forbes, A., Ritchie, S., Walker, J., Young, N. (2020). Applications of Two-Eyed Seeing in Primary Research Focused on Indigenous Health: A Scoping Review. International Journal of Qualitative Methods Volume 19: 1–18.	Submit quiz questions for this week's content by Mar 29 Mar 29: Survey critical review assignment due
Week 12 Mar 30 – Apr 8	Research to Action Knowledge translation <u>Guest:</u> Emily Drake, Health Studies prof.	Chapter 13: Knowledge Translation (from Health Research Methods: A Canadian Perspective) Note: No class on April 3 (Good Friday)	Submit quiz questions for this week's content by Apr 2. Final Quiz: during class time April 8